

Morocco



Area 172,317 sq miles
(446,300 sq km)
Population 32.3 million
Capital Rabat
Currency Moroccan dirham
Official languages Arabic
and Tamazight
Life expectancy 71 years



The Kingdom of Morocco, a former French colony, is located in North Africa. It is a constitutional monarchy—the prime minister heads the government while the king is the spiritual leader. About 99 percent of the population follow the Sunni Islam faith. Morocco's key economic sectors are tourism, textiles, mining, agriculture, and leather. In 2000, large oil and gas deposits were discovered in the Sahara Desert, which spans the southeastern part of Morocco. The country's rich culture is a blend of Arab, Berber, African, and European influences.



▲ BABOUCHES

A trademark of the city of Marrakesh in Morocco, babouches are handmade heel-less slippers made from leather. They are very popular with the tourists in Morocco.

Cape Verde



Area 1,557 sq miles
(4,033 sq km)
Population 500,000
Capital Praia
Currency Escudo
Official language Portuguese
Life expectancy 71 years



Off the west coast of Africa is Cape Verde, an archipelago of 10 islands located in the Atlantic Ocean. Most of the islands are mountainous and volcanic. A Portuguese colony until 1975, Cape Verde has been one of the most stable democracies in Africa. Around 50 percent of the population lives on the island of Santiago. The majority of Cape Verde's population is a Portuguese-African mix, and the remainder is largely made up of Africans who are descended either from slaves or from more recent immigrants from the African mainland. Tourism and fishing are important sources of revenue in Cape Verde. The islands face severe droughts and water supply problems. Lack of agricultural land has led to a shortfall in food production, making it dependent on aid from other countries.

Senegal



Area 75,749 sq miles
(196,190 sq km)
Population 12.8 million
Capital Dakar
Currency CFA franc
Official language French
Life expectancy 63 years



Mostly low-lying, Senegal is made up of open savanna and semidesert in the north, and thicker savanna in the south. Senegal gained independence from France in 1960, after which it was ruled by President Léopold Senghor for nearly two decades. Although Senegal became a multiparty democracy in 1981, the ruling Socialist Party stayed in power until 2000. Senegal's economy is supported by fishing, the production and export of

► SENEGAL PARROT

A shy bird that feeds on fruit, seeds, and blossoms, the Senegal parrot lives in the open woodlands in west Africa. However, it is considered a farm pest since it often feeds on corn or millet.



Mauritania



Area 397,955 sq miles
(1,030,700 sq km)
Population 3.5 million
Capital Nouakchott
Currency Ouguiya
Official language Arabic
Life expectancy 64 years



The Islamic Republic of Mauritania lies in northwest Africa. Much of its territory is covered by the Sahara Desert. Mauritania has recently changed from being a country of nomads to a largely urban-dwelling one, though many people retain their traditions. The country is made up of the Maures, who are politically and economically dominant, and a black minority. The main mineral resources found here are iron (from the Cominor mine at Zouérat), gypsum, copper, gold, diamonds, oil, phosphate, and silver. Mauritania's offshore fishing is among the best in West Africa.

